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Culture (OWC): [Gusii \(FL08\)](#)

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Sub Region: Eastern Africa

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Coverage Date: 1992-1995

Place Coverage: Southwestern Kenya, East Africa

Section Title(S): Case #1 • Case #2

Case #1

The first incident of a son inciting the burning of his mother occurred at MwaBoera village on the eastern hills of the Keera region, near the south Mugirango-Maasai border. A child had died but no one thought the circumstances of the death to be unusual except the parents and adult siblings of the deceased. They believed that the 80-year-old Nyarinda was the one who had bewitched her own grandchild. On burial day, many mourners attended the funeral. As soon as the deceased was laid to rest, the male siblings of the deceased seized their paternal grandmother, bound her hands and feet, removed the grass-thatched roof from her granary, covered her with it, and then set it ablaze. According to Oeri, a Christian and headmaster of a nearby primary school who was present,

I thought the whole thing was a joke. In fact, people were laughing, thinking that the boys were merely scaring their grandmother into confessing that she had bewitched the child. Suddenly, the fire engulfed [the grass-thatched roof of] the granary. It was at 3 o'clock in the afternoon and the sun was hot. Then the people who had been laughing stopped laughing and started yelling, "Oh, oh. ..." No one went to help; the sun was too hot. Each one hurried away. No one wanted to be going to court to testify. And the old woman just perished like that! I was shocked.

Nyarinda's eldest son, the father of the deceased child, had incited his sons to burn her. In Gusii, it is the customary duty of grandsons to bury their grandmothers. My informants could not recall anyone accuse Nyarinda of witchcraft. Rather, she was a circumciser—a traditional surgeon who performed clitoridectomy—a woman respected in the community.

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Since this was a domestic homicide occurring within the homestead, no one reported the matter to the police. The matter ended there and then but the event provided the people of Keera, especially those who had witnessed the lynching, with a curious humorous line they would be quoting when imagining

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Case #2

On Saturday, January 9, 1993, the assistant chief for Keera region convened a *baraza* (a public meeting convened and chaired by a district  12 office, a chief, and an assistant chief or his delegate) to discuss and resolve two issues of general concern in his sublocation—intensified witchcraft and cattle rustling. His choice of venue was not coincidental. The land on which they sat belonged to a 50-year-old man named Moturi who, at the time of the meeting, lay on his deathbed. Moturi's illness began to show when he started to “thin out.” He had stomach pains and soon developed diarrhea. He went to hospital. In the hospital, his body became swollen, his scalp developed scalds and his hair became thin. After being rehydrated, he went home, but continued to ail. His kinsfolk called in a sorcerer (*omonyamosiira*) to treat him. For a time, the patient's condition seemed to improve. Then it took a turn for the worse, necessitating the convening of this meeting because of suspicions of Kebwesi.

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